

Gridel 1861

Soirées chrétiennes — Explication du catéchisme: les pasteurs légitimes (*Christian Evenings — Explanation of the Catechism: legitimate pastors*)

by Abbé Gridel; third edition, 1861, with the approval of the Bishop of Nancy

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- French text from the Google Books scan of the third edition (1861), pp. 252–253; running title “Soirées chrétiennes.” OCR corrected against the page images.
- Translation of the original text performed by AI (claude-fable-5).
- Last Edit: July 5, 2026.
- Version: 1.0
- Selection pages: 252-253 (chapter on the Ninth Article, “Le Saint-Esprit” / the Church)

Note on this selection: a catechetical witness a decade before Vatican I — valuable because it shows the acceptance-criterion taught, with episcopal approval, as the ordinary faithful’s practical rule. Asked how an unlearned Christian can know that the Pope is a legitimate pastor, the catechism answers from the peaceful adhesion of the body of pastors: a newly elected pope, “if he were not such, the body of the pastors would not recognize him as head of the Church. Therefore, if a member of the faithful hears no protest from his pastors against the Pope, he must hold him for legitimate.” The same descending chain covers bishop and parish priest, concluding that “every Catholic can know in a certain manner whether his pastor is legitimate” — Cano’s principle that the Church’s rulers must be knowable (Book IV, ch. 3) and Gonet’s implicit-faith mechanism, in classroom form. Note what the text does and does not do: it teaches the fact-side of the question (certain knowability through the Church’s acceptance) and is silent on the theological note — exactly the configuration of the manual tradition (cf. the 1933 Boulenger entry).

The Holy Spirit — The Church: legitimate pastors (pp. 252–253)

Why do you say: under the guidance of legitimate pastors? — Because in the Church, as in every society, there must be heads, and legitimate heads, whom all men are bound to obey; and he who rejects the authority of the heads cannot be a member of the society. — Why do you say: legitimate pastors, and not: pastors in general? — Because in the Church, as in every society, obedience is owed only to superiors instituted according to the fundamental constitution of that society. — Why do you call the heads of the Church pastors? — Because the Church is like a flock of sheep whose head, or sovereign shepherd, is Jesus Christ. Now, just as sheep, incapable of guiding themselves, need a shepherd to lead and defend them, so the faithful, unable to guide or defend themselves, need heads or pastors to direct them and keep them from perishing.

How can an unlearned Christian know that the Pope, his diocesan bishop, and his parish priest are legitimate pastors? — He knows it by the very fact of their institution. When a Pope dies, the cardinals elect another, who by his election becomes the legitimate Pope. If he were not such, the body of the pastors would not recognize him as head of the Church. Therefore, if a member of the faithful hears no protest from his pastors against the Pope, he must hold him for legitimate.

In the same way, when a bishop arrives in his diocese, he presents to the priests assisting at his installation the letters which attest the mission he has received from the Pope, and without which they would not recognize him as their legitimate superior. If therefore the priests and the instructed laity have received the new pontiff as bishop, the faithful man can be certain that he is a legitimate pastor. It is the same with a priest who, on taking possession of his parish, must show the commission he has received from his bishop.

Therefore every Catholic can know in a certain manner whether his pastor is legitimate. To be certain that he himself is a member of the Church, it is enough that he can say to himself: I am united to my parish priest; my parish priest is united to his bishop; and my bishop is united to the Pope. Now, as we have just said, he can always easily assure himself of these three facts.